wants to balance its budget soon realises that in addition to priests and poets who can mesmerise people with stories, it needs accountants who know their way around the various types of lists.

Lists and stories are complementary. National myths legitimise the tax records, while the tax records help transform aspirational stories into concrete schools and hospitals. Something analogous happens in the field of finance. The dollar, the pound sterling and the bitcoin are all brought into being by persuading people to believe a story, and tales told by bankers, finance ministers and investment gurus raise or lower their value. When the chairperson of the Federal Reserve wants to curb inflation, when a finance minister wants to pass a new budget, and when a tech entrepreneur wants to draw investors, they all turn to storytelling. But to actually manage a bank, a budget or a start-up, lists are essential.

The big problem with lists, and the crucial difference between lists and stories, is that lists tend to be far more boring than stories, which means that while we easily remember stories, we find it difficult to remember lists. This is an important fact about how the human brain processes information. Evolution has adapted our brains to be good at absorbing, retaining and processing even very large quantities of information when they are shaped into a story. The *Ramayana*, one of the foundational tales of Hindu mythology, is twenty-four thousand verses long and runs to about seventeen hundred pages in modern editions, yet despite its enormous length generations of Hindus succeeded in remembering and reciting it by heart.[9]

In the twentieth and twenty-first centuries, the *Ramayana* was repeatedly adapted for film and television. In 1987–88, a seventy-eight-episode version (running to about 2,730 minutes) was the most watched television series in the world, with more than 650 million viewers. According to a BBC report, when episodes were aired, ‘streets would be deserted, shops would be closed, and people would bathe and garland their TV sets’. During the 2020 COVID-19 lockdown the series was re-aired and again became the most watched show in the world.[10] While modern TV audiences need not memorise any texts by heart, it is noteworthy how easy they find it to follow the intricate plots of epic dramas, detective thrillers and soap operas, recalling who each character is and how they are related to numerous others. We are so accustomed to performing such feats of memory that we seldom consider how extraordinary they are.